

2020-2024 General Conference Constitutional Amendments

The General Conference of The United Methodist Church met in May 2024 in Charlotte, NC. The following amendments to the Constitution were adopted by a 2/3 majority vote and now come to the Annual Conferences for consideration and a vote. The Constitution is printed in *The Book of Discipline of The United Methodist Church*.

Elders and Deacons in Full Connection are the only clergy who can vote on Constitutional Amendments. All lay members of the annual conference can vote on Constitutional Amendments. The aggregate vote of all annual conferences will be compiled, and the results will be announced late in the fall. Annual Conferences are not allowed to publish conference votes. A 2/3 aggregate vote is required for adoption. The proposed changes are indicated by a strike-through for deletions and underscore for additions.

[Editorial Note: Numbering of paragraphs will be subject to the final editing of *The Book of Discipline 2020/2024*.]

Proposed Constitutional Amendment I – Regionalization

Amendment with changes included:

AMEND ¶¶ 9, (which shall be renumbered ¶ 10), 10 (which shall be renumbered ¶ 9), 15, 16, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 38, 39, 40, 46, 48, 49, 50, 52, 56, 61 and add new 13 as follows:

¶ 10 9. ~~Article III~~ Article II.—There shall be ~~central~~ regional conferences for the work of the worldwide Church outside the United States of America and, if necessary, provisional ~~central~~ regional conferences, all with such powers, duties, and privileges as are hereinafter set forth, provided that in The United Methodist Church there shall be no regional or jurisdictional conference based on any ground other than geographical division.

¶ 9-10. ~~Article II~~ Article III.—There ~~shall~~ may be jurisdictional conferences for the work of the Church in the United States of America, with such powers, duties, and privileges as are hereinafter set forth, provided that in The United Methodist Church there shall be no jurisdictional ~~or central~~ conference based on any ground other than geographical and regional division.

(NEW - Renumber subsequent paragraphs) **¶ 13. Article VI.** - The General Conference, regional conferences, jurisdictional conferences, and annual conferences shall have autonomy of action within the limits fixed by the Constitution, provided that any legislation enacted within the respective powers of a conference but overlapping with the powers of another shall not be rendered invalid, unless its purpose and substance are beyond the authority of the enacting body.

¶ 15. Article III.—The General Conference shall fix the ratio of representation in the General, ~~jurisdictional~~, and ~~central~~ regional conferences from the annual conferences, missionary conferences, and the provisional annual conferences, computed on a two-factor basis: (1) the number of clergy members of the annual conference and the missionary conference, and (2) the number of professing members in the annual conference and the missionary conference, provided that each annual conference, missionary conference, or provisional annual conference shall be entitled to at least one clergy and one lay delegate in the General Conference and also in the ~~jurisdictional or central~~ regional conference.

In a regional conference with jurisdictions, the regional conference shall fix the ratio of representation in its jurisdictional conferences from the annual conferences, missionary conferences, and the provisional annual conferences, computed on a two-factor basis: (1) the number of clergy members of the annual conference and the missionary conference, and (2) the number of professing members in the annual conference and the missionary conference, provided that each annual conference, missionary conference, or provisional annual conference shall be entitled to at least one clergy and one lay delegate in the jurisdictional conference and further provided that all general and regional conference delegates will be members of their respective jurisdictional conferences.

¶ 16. Article IV.—The General Conference shall have full legislative power over all matters distinctively connectional, subject to the limits fixed by the Constitution, and in the exercise thereof shall have authority as follows:

...

16.3. To define and fix the powers and duties of regional conferences, jurisdictional conferences, annual conferences, provisional annual conferences, missionary conferences and missions, ~~and of central conferences~~, district conferences, charge conferences, and congregational meetings.

16.4. To provide for the organization, promotion, and administration of the work of the worldwide Church outside the United States of America.

...

16.10. To fix a uniform basis upon which bishops shall be elected by the jurisdictional conferences and to determine the number of bishops that may be elected by ~~central~~ regional conferences without jurisdictions.

...

16.12. To change the number and the boundaries of regional conferences and to change the number and the boundaries of jurisdictional conferences upon the consent of a majority of the annual conferences in each jurisdictional conference involved.

...

16.17. To legislate what is non-adaptable for regional conferences by a 60% majority vote, while respecting the powers given to regional conferences according to ¶31.5.

¶ 23. Article I.—The jurisdictional conferences shall be composed of as many representatives from the annual conferences and missionary conferences as shall be determined by a uniform basis established by the ~~General Conference~~ regional conference where jurisdictions exist, provided that no jurisdictional conference shall have fewer than 100 delegates. The missionary conferences shall be considered as annual conferences for the purpose of this article.

¶ 24. **Article II.**—All jurisdictional conferences shall have the same status and the same privileges of action within the limits fixed by the Constitution. The ratio of representation of the annual conferences and missionary conferences in the General Conference and the regional conference where jurisdictions exist shall be the same for all jurisdictional conferences.

¶ 25. **Article III.**—The General Conferences regional conference where jurisdictions exist shall fix the basis of representation in the jurisdictional conferences, provided that the jurisdictional conferences shall be composed of an equal number of clergy and lay delegates to be elected by the annual conferences, the missionary conferences and the provisional annual conferences.

¶ 26. **Article IV.**—Each jurisdictional conference shall meet at the time determined by the Council College of Bishops of the regional conference where jurisdictions exist or its delegated committee, each jurisdictional conference convening on the same date as the others and at a place selected by the jurisdictional committee on entertainment, appointed by its respective College of Bishops unless such a committee has been appointed by the preceding jurisdictional conference.

¶ 27. **Article V.**—The jurisdictional conferences shall have the following powers and duties and such others as may be conferred by the General Conferences:

...

4. To determine the boundaries of their annual conferences, provided that there shall be no annual conference with a membership of fewer than fifty clergy in full connection, except by the consent of the General Conference regional conference where jurisdictions exist.

5. To make rules and regulations for the administration of the work of the Church within the jurisdiction, subject to such powers as have been or shall be vested in the General Conference and in the regional conferences.

6. To appoint a committee on appeals to hear and determine the appeal of a traveling preacher clergy or lay member of that jurisdiction from the decision of a trial committee.

Section V. Central-Regional Conferences

¶ 28. **Article I.**—There shall be central regional conferences for the work of the worldwide Church outside the United States of America with such powers, duties, powers, and privileges as are hereinafter set forth, to be exercised equitably across the regional conferences, subject to limits fixed by the Constitution.

The number and boundaries of the central conferences shall be determined by the Uniting Conference. Subsequently the General Conference shall have authority to change the number and boundaries of central conferences. The central conferences shall have the duties, powers, and privileges hereinafter set forth.

1. Initially, the number and boundaries of the regional conferences shall be as follows:

a) There shall be a regional conference for the work of the Church in the United States of America that includes all of the areas that comprise the jurisdictional conferences identified in Division Two, Section VII, ¶ 37.

b) The central conferences or provisional central conferences which existed prior to the postponed 2020 General Conference shall become regional or provisional regional conferences.

2. The General Conference shall have the authority to change the number and boundaries of regional conferences and provisional regional conferences.

¶ 29. **Article II.**—The central regional conferences shall be composed of as many delegates as shall be determined by a basis established by the General Conference. The delegates shall be clergy and lay in equal numbers.

¶ 30. **Article III.**—The central regional conferences shall meet within the year succeeding the meeting of the General Conference at such times and places as shall have been determined by the preceding respective central regional conferences or by commissions appointed by them or by the General Conference. The date and place of the first meeting succeeding the Uniting Conference shall be fixed by the bishops of the respective central conferences, or in such manner as shall be determined by the General Conference.

¶ 31. **Article IV.**—The central regional conferences shall have the following powers and duties as the special conditions and the mission of the Church in the area require, subject to the limits fixed by the Constitution, and such others as may be conferred by the General Conference:

1. To promote the evangelistic, educational, missionary, social-concern, and benevolent interests and institutions of the Church within their own boundaries.

2. In regional conferences without jurisdictions, To elect the bishops for the respective central regional conferences in number as may be determined from time to time, upon a basis fixed by the General Conference; to fix the tenure of their bishops, the episcopal areas and residences, and to assign the bishops who are to reside in the respective regional conference to their areas; and to cooperate in carrying out such plans for the support of their bishops as may be determined by the General Conference.

3. To establish and constitute such central regional conference boards as may be required and to elect their administrative officers.

4. To determine the number, names, and boundaries of the annual conferences in accordance with ¶ 40 within their respective areas.

5. To make such legislate and make rules and regulations for the administration of the work within their boundaries including such changes and adaptations of the General Discipline as follows, as the conditions in the respective areas may require, subject to the powers that have been or shall be vested in the General Conference while upholding the Constitution and the

decisions of General Conference in accordance with ¶ 16.17:

a) To establish and publish a regional *Discipline* with legislation and provisions pertaining to the regional, annual, district, and charge conferences within its boundaries, including qualifications and educational requirements of clergy and specialized lay ministries, and forms of organization according to the laws of the country or countries.

b) To set standards of character and other qualifications for admission of lay members.

c) To acknowledge annual conferences as the basic bodies of the church (¶ 33) voting on all matters relating to the character and conference relations of its clergy members, and therefore considering the requirements set forth in a regional *Discipline* regarding specialized lay ministry and license, ordination, or conference membership, as minimum requirements.

d) To establish and publish a regional hymnal and ritual of the Church, including ecclesial acts of marriage and burial, subject to the limitations of the first and second Restrictive Rules, but authorizing to interpret Article XXIII of the Articles of Religion so as to recognize the governments of the country or countries.

e) To allow the annual conferences to adopt structures adequate to their mission while upholding mandated structures. When adapting the investigative and trial process, each regional *Book of Discipline* shall guarantee confidentiality, protections of the accused, protection of the accusers along with the ability to adapt the process based on the legal system of each country.

6. To appoint a judicial court to determine legal questions arising from the rules, regulations, and such revised, adapted, or new sections of the ~~central~~ regional conference *Discipline* enacted by the ~~central~~ regional conference.

7. To adopt rules of procedure governing the investigation and trial of its clergy, including bishops, and lay members of the Church and to provide the necessary means and methods of implementing the said rules; provided, however, that the ordained ministers shall not be deprived of the right of trial by a clergy committee, and lay members of the Church of the right of trial by a duly constituted committee of lay members; and to make changes in the chargeable offenses and their penalties.

To a regional conference or a jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, shall appoint a committee on appeals to hear and determine the appeal of a traveling-preacher clergy or lay member of that ~~central~~ the respective conference from the decision of a committee on trial.

¶ 32. **Article I.**—The annual conference shall be composed of clergy and lay members. The clergy membership shall consist of deacons and elders in full connection, provisional members, associate members, and local pastors under appointment. The lay membership shall consist of professing lay members elected by each charge, the diaconal ministers, the active deaconesses, and home missionaries under episcopal appointment within the bounds of the annual conference, the conference president of United Methodist Women, the conference president of United Methodist Men, the conference lay leader, district lay leaders, the conference director of Lay Servant Ministries, conference secretary of Global Ministries (if lay), the president or equivalent officer of the conference young adult organization, the president of the conference youth organization, the chair of the annual conference college student organization, and one young person between the ages of twelve (12) and seventeen (17) and one young person between the ages of eighteen (18) and thirty (30) from each district to be selected in such a manner as may be determined by the annual conference. In the annual conferences of the ~~central~~ regional conferences outside the USA, the four-year participation and the two-year membership requirements may be waived by the annual conference for young persons under thirty (30) years of age. Such persons must be professing members of The United Methodist Church and active participants at the time of election. Each charge served by more than one clergy shall be entitled to as many lay members as there are clergy members. The lay members shall have been for the two years next preceding their election members of The United Methodist Church and shall have been active participants in The United Methodist Church for at least four years next preceding their election.

If the lay membership should number less than the clergy members of the annual conference, the annual conference shall, by its own formula, provide for the election of additional lay members to equalize lay and clergy membership of the annual conference.

¶ 33. **Article II.**—The annual conference is the basic body in the Church and as such shall have reserved to it the right to vote on all constitutional amendments, on the election of clergy and lay delegates to the General Conference and their respective regional jurisdictional or central conferences, as well as jurisdictional conference if its regional conference has jurisdictions, on all matters relating to the character and conference relations of its clergy members, and on the ordination of clergy and such other rights as have not been delegated to the General Conference under the Constitution, with the exception that the lay members may not vote on matters of ordination, character, and conference relations of clergy except that the lay members of the conference board of ordained ministry and the committee on investigation may vote on matters of ordination, character, and conference relations of clergy, with the further exception that lay members of the district committee on ordained ministry be full participating members of the district committee on ordained ministry with vote. It shall discharge such duties and exercise such powers as the General Conference under the Constitution may determine.

¶ 34. **Article III.**—The annual conference shall elect clergy and lay delegates to the General Conference and to its jurisdictional or central respective regional conference as well as jurisdictional conference, if its regional conference has jurisdictions, in the manner provided in this section, Articles IV and V. Such elections shall include open nominations from the floor by the annual conference, and delegates shall be elected by a minimum of a simple majority of the ballots cast. The persons first elected up to the number determined by the ratio for representation in the General Conference shall be representatives in that body. Additional delegates shall be elected to complete the number determined by the ratio for representation in the jurisdictional or central regional conference, who, together with those first elected as above, shall be delegates in the jurisdictional or central regional conference. The additional delegates to the jurisdictional or central regional conference shall in the order of their election be the reserve delegates to the General Conference. The annual conference shall also elect reserve clergy and lay delegates to the jurisdictional or central regional conference as it may deem desirable. These reserve clergy and lay delegates to the jurisdictional or central regional conferences

may act as reserve delegates to the General Conference when it is evident that not enough reserve delegates are in attendance at the General Conference.

In regional conferences with jurisdictions, all general and regional conference delegates shall be delegates to the jurisdictional conference. Whenever possible, reserve delegates to the regional conference shall also serve in order of election as delegates to the jurisdictional conference, with any reserve delegates who cannot be seated as jurisdictional delegates becoming reserve delegates to the jurisdictional conference. As needed, additional delegates shall be elected to complete the number determined by the ratio for representation in the jurisdictional conference. The annual conference may also elect additional reserve clergy and lay delegates to the jurisdictional conference as it may deem desirable.

¶ 35. Article IV.—The clergy delegates to the General Conference and to their respective regional and jurisdictional or central conference as well as jurisdictional conference, if its regional conference has jurisdictions, shall be elected from the clergy members in full connection and shall be elected by the clergy members of the annual conference or provisional annual conference who are deacons and elders in full connection, associate members, and those provisional members who have completed all of their educational requirements and local pastors who have completed course of study or an M. Div. degree or its equivalent in regional conferences outside of the USA and have served a minimum of two consecutive years under appointment immediately preceding the election.

¶ 36. Article V.—The lay delegates to the General Conference and to their respective regional conference, and jurisdictional or central conferences as well as jurisdictional conference if its regional conference has jurisdictions, shall be elected by the lay members of the annual conference or provisional annual conference without regard to age, provided such delegates shall have been professing members of The United Methodist Church for at least two years next preceding their election, and shall have been active participants in The United Methodist Church for at least four years next preceding their election, and are members thereof within the annual conference electing them at the time of holding the General Conference and jurisdictional or central regional conferences as well as the jurisdictional conferences, if its regional conference has jurisdictions.

[DELETE ¶ 38 and ¶ 39 and renumber all of the articles within its section and renumber all subsequent paragraphs of the Constitution.]

¶ 38. Article II.—The work of the Church outside the United States of America may be formed into central conferences, the number and boundaries of which shall be determined by the Uniting Conference, the General Conference having authority subsequently to make changes in the number and boundaries:

¶ 39. Article III.—Changes in the number, names, and boundaries of the jurisdictional conferences may be effected by the General Conference upon the consent of a majority of the annual conferences of each of the jurisdictional conferences involved:

¶ 40. Article IV II.—The number, names, and boundaries of the annual conferences and episcopal areas shall be determined by the respective regional conferences or by the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions. jurisdictional conferences in the United States of America and by the central conferences outside the United States of America according to the provisions under the respective powers and pursuant to the respective structures of the jurisdictional and the central conferences. The authority of regional and jurisdictional and central conferences provided herein is not circumscribed or limited by the authority provided to the College of Bishops to arrange a plan of episcopal supervision.

¶ 46. Article II.—The bishops shall be elected by the respective regional conferences or by the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, jurisdictional and central conferences and consecrated in the historic manner at such time and place as may be fixed by the General Conference for those elected by the jurisdictions and by each central regional conference for those elected by such central conference, provided that episcopal elections in central regional conferences without jurisdictions shall be held at a regular, not an extra, session of the central such regional conference, except in the case where an unexpected vacancy must be filled.

¶ 48. Article IV.—The bishops of each jurisdictional and central conference regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, shall constitute a College of Bishops, and such College of Bishops shall arrange the plan of episcopal supervision of the annual conferences, missionary conferences, and missions within their respective territories.

¶ 49. Article V.—The bishops shall have residential and presidential supervision in the jurisdictional or central conferences their respective regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, in which they are elected or to which they are transferred. Bishops may be transferred from one jurisdiction to another jurisdiction for presidential and residential supervision under the following conditions: (1) The transfer of bishops may be on either of two bases: (a) a jurisdiction that receives a bishop by transfer from another jurisdiction may transfer to that jurisdiction or to a third jurisdiction one of its own bishops eligible for transfer, so that the number transferred in by each jurisdiction shall be balanced by the number transferred out; or (b) a jurisdiction may receive a bishop from another jurisdiction and not transfer out a member of its own College of Bishops. (2) No bishop shall be transferred unless that bishop shall have specifically consented. (3) No bishop shall be eligible for transfer unless the bishop shall have served one quadrennium in the jurisdiction that elected the bishop to the episcopacy. (4) All such transfers shall require the approval by a majority vote of the members present and voting of the jurisdictional committees on episcopacy of the jurisdictions that are involved. After the above procedures have been followed, the transferring bishop shall become a member of the receiving College of Bishops and shall be subject to residential assignment by that jurisdictional conference.

A bishop may be assigned by the Council of Bishops for presidential service or other temporary service in another jurisdiction than that which elected the bishop, provided that the request is made by a majority of the bishops in the jurisdiction of the proposed service.

In the case of an emergency in any jurisdiction or central regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, through the death or disability of a bishop or other cause, the Council of Bishops may assign a bishop from another jurisdiction or

~~central regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, to the work of the said jurisdiction or central regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, with the consent of a majority of the bishops of that jurisdiction or central regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions.~~

¶ 50. Article VI.—~~The bishops, both active and retired, of The Evangelical United Brethren Church and of The Methodist Church at the time union is consummated shall be bishops of The United Methodist Church. The bishops of The Methodist Church elected by the jurisdictions, the active bishops of The Evangelical United Brethren Church at the time of union, and bBishops elected by the jurisdictions of The United Methodist Church shall have life tenure. Each bBishops elected by a central regional conference without jurisdictions of The United Methodist Church shall have such tenure as the central regional conference electing him them shall have determined.~~

~~The regional conference or the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, jurisdictional conference shall elect a standing committee on episcopacy to consist of one clergy and one lay delegate from each annual conference, on nomination of the annual conference delegation. The committee shall review the work of the bishops, pass on their character and official administration, and report to the its respective regional conference or jurisdiction, at conference if a region has jurisdictions, its findings for such action as the conference may deem appropriate within its constitutional warrant of power. The committee shall recommend the assignments of the bishops to their respective residences for final action by the jurisdictional respective regional conference or the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions.~~

These provisions shall not preclude the adoption by the General Conference of provisions for the Council of Bishops to hold its individual members accountable for their work, both as general superintendents and as presidents and residents in episcopal areas.

¶ 52. Article VIII.—~~The bishops of the several regional jurisdictional and central conferences shall preside in the sessions of their respective conferences. If a regional conference has jurisdictions, the bishops shall also preside in the session of their respective jurisdictional conference.~~

¶ 56. Article II.—The Judicial Council shall have authority:

1. To determine the constitutionality of any act of the General Conference upon an appeal of a majority of the Council of Bishops or one-fifth of the members of the General Conference and to determine the constitutionality of any act of a regional or jurisdictional or central conference upon an appeal of a majority of the bishops of that regional or jurisdictional or central conference or upon the appeal of one-fifth of the members of that regional or jurisdictional or central conference.

...

4. To hear and determine the legality of any action taken therein by any General Conference board, ~~or regional, or jurisdictional or central~~ conference board or body, upon appeal by one-third of the members thereof, or upon request of the Council of Bishops or a majority of the bishops of a regional or jurisdictional or a central conference.

...

¶ 61. Article III.—~~A regional or jurisdictional or central conference may by a majority vote propose changes in the Constitution of the Church, and such proposed changes shall be submitted to the next General Conference. If the General Conference adopts the measure by a two-thirds vote, it shall be submitted to the annual conferences according to the provision for amendments.~~

The ratification process by the annual conferences for the constitutional amendments in this petition shall begin no later than 30 days after the adjournment of the postponed 2020 General Conference.

[If ratified, the paragraphs would read as follows:]

¶ 9. Article II.—There shall be regional conferences for the work of the worldwide Church and, if necessary, provisional regional conferences, all with such powers, duties, and privileges as are hereinafter set forth, provided that in The United Methodist Church there shall be no regional or jurisdictional conference based on any ground other than geographical division.

¶ 10. Article III.—There may be jurisdictional conferences for the work of the Church, with such powers, duties, and privileges as are hereinafter set forth, provided that in The United Methodist Church there shall be no jurisdictional conference based on any ground other than geographical and regional division.

¶ 13. Article VI.—The General Conference, regional conferences, jurisdictional conferences, and annual conferences shall have autonomy of action within the limits fixed by the Constitution, provided that any legislation enacted within the respective powers of a conference but overlapping with the powers of another shall not be rendered invalid, unless its purpose and substance are beyond the authority of the enacting body.

¶ 15. Article III.—The General Conference shall fix the ratio of representation in the General and regional conferences from the annual conferences, missionary conferences, and the provisional annual conferences, computed on a two-factor basis: (1) the number of clergy members of the annual conference and the missionary conference, and (2) the number of professing members in the annual conference and the missionary conference, provided that each annual conference, missionary conference, or provisional annual conference shall be entitled to at least one clergy and one lay delegate in the General Conference and also in the regional conference.

In a regional conference with jurisdictions, the regional conference shall fix the ratio of representation in its jurisdictional conferences from the annual conferences, missionary conferences, and the provisional annual conferences, computed on a two-factor basis: (1) the number of clergy members of the annual conference and the missionary conference, and (2) the number of professing members in the annual conference and the missionary conference, provided that each annual conference, missionary conference, or provisional annual conference shall be entitled to at least one clergy and one lay delegate in the jurisdictional conference and further provided that all general and regional conference delegates will be members of their respective jurisdictional conferences.

¶ **16. Article IV.**—The General Conference shall have full legislative power over all matters distinctively connectional, subject to the limits fixed by the Constitution, and in the exercise thereof shall have authority as follows:

...

16.3. To define and fix the powers and duties of regional conferences, jurisdictional conferences, annual conferences, provisional annual conferences, missionary conferences and missions, district conferences, charge conferences, and congregational meetings.

16.4. To provide for the organization, promotion, and administration of the work of the worldwide Church.

...

16.10. To fix a uniform basis upon which bishops shall be elected by the jurisdictional conferences and to determine the number of bishops that may be elected by regional conferences without jurisdictions.

...

16.12. To change the number and the boundaries of regional conferences, and to change the number and the boundaries of jurisdictional conferences upon the consent of a majority of the annual conferences in each jurisdictional conference involved.

...

16.17. To legislate what is non-adaptable for regional conferences by a 60% majority vote, while respecting the powers given to regional conferences according to ¶31.5.

¶ **23. Article I.**—The jurisdictional conferences shall be composed of as many representatives from the annual conferences and missionary conferences as shall be determined by a uniform basis established by the regional conference where jurisdictions exist, provided that no jurisdictional conference shall have fewer than 100 delegates. The missionary conferences shall be considered as annual conferences for the purpose of this article.

¶ **24. Article II.**—All jurisdictional conferences shall have the same status and the same privileges of action within the limits fixed by the Constitution. The ratio of representation of the annual conferences and missionary conferences in the General Conference and the regional conference where jurisdictions exist shall be the same for all jurisdictional conferences.

¶ **25. Article III.**—The regional conference where jurisdictions exist shall fix the basis of representation in the jurisdictional conferences, provided that the jurisdictional conferences shall be composed of an equal number of clergy and lay delegates to be elected by the annual conferences, the missionary conferences and the provisional annual conferences.

¶ **26. Article IV.**—Each jurisdictional conference shall meet at the time determined by the College of Bishops of the regional conference where jurisdictions exist or its delegated committee, each jurisdictional conference convening on the same date as the others and at a place selected by the jurisdictional committee on entertainment, appointed by its respective College of Bishops unless such a committee has been appointed by the preceding jurisdictional conference.

¶ **27. Article V.**—The jurisdictional conferences shall have the following powers and duties and such others as may be conferred by the General Conferences:

...

4. To determine the boundaries of their annual conferences, provided that there shall be no annual conference with a membership of fewer than fifty clergy in full connection, except by the consent of the regional conference where jurisdictions exist.

5. To make rules and regulations for the administration of the work of the Church within the jurisdiction, subject to such powers as have been or shall be vested in the General Conference and in the regional conferences.

6. To appoint a committee on appeals to hear and determine the appeal of a clergy or lay member of that jurisdiction from the decision of a trial committee.

Section V. Regional Conferences

¶ **28. Article I.**—There shall be regional conferences for the work of the worldwide Church with such powers, duties, and privileges as are hereinafter set forth, to be exercised equitably across the regional conferences, subject to limits fixed by the Constitution.

1. Initially, the number and boundaries of the regional conferences shall be as follows:

a) There shall be a regional conference for the work of the Church in the United States of America that includes all of the areas that comprise the jurisdictional conferences identified in Division Two, Section VII, ¶ 37.

b) The central conferences or provisional central conferences which existed prior to the postponed 2020 General Conference shall become regional or provisional regional conferences.

2. The General Conference shall have the authority to change the number and boundaries of regional conferences and provisional regional conferences.

¶ **29. Article II.**—The regional conferences shall be composed of as many delegates as shall be determined by a basis established by the General Conference. The delegates shall be clergy and lay in equal numbers.

¶ **30. Article III.**—The regional conferences shall meet within the year succeeding the meeting of the General Conference at such times and places as shall have been determined by the preceding respective regional conferences or by commissions appointed by them or by the General Conference.

¶ **31. Article IV.**—The regional conferences shall have the following powers and duties as the special conditions and the mission of the Church in the area require, subject to the limits fixed by the Constitution, and such others as may be conferred by the General Conference:

1. To promote the evangelistic, educational, missionary, social-concern, and benevolent interests and institutions of the Church within their own boundaries.
2. In regional conferences without jurisdictions, to elect the bishops for the respective regional conferences in number as may be determined from time to time, upon a basis fixed by the General Conference; to fix the tenure of their bishops, the episcopal areas and residences, and to assign the bishops who are to reside in the respective regional conference to their areas; and to cooperate in carrying out such plans for the support of their bishops as may be determined by the General Conference.
3. To establish and constitute such regional conference boards as may be required and to elect their administrative officers.
4. To determine the number, names, and boundaries of the annual conferences in accordance with ¶ 40 .
5. To legislate rules and regulations for the administration of the work within their boundaries including changes and adaptations of the general *Discipline* as follows, while upholding the Constitution and the decisions of General Conference in accordance with ¶ 16.17:
 - a) To establish and publish a regional *Discipline* with legislation and provisions pertaining to the regional, annual, district, and charge conferences within its boundaries, including qualifications and educational requirements of clergy and specialized lay ministries, and forms of organization according to the laws of the country or countries.
 - b) To set standards of character and other qualifications for admission of lay members.
 - c) To acknowledge annual conferences as the basic bodies of the church (¶ 33) voting on all matters relating to the character and conference relations of its clergy members, and therefore considering the requirements set forth in a regional *Discipline* regarding specialized lay ministry and license, ordination, or conference membership, as minimum requirements.
 - d) To establish and publish a regional hymnal and ritual of the Church, including ecclesial acts of marriage and burial, subject to the limitations of the first and second Restrictive Rules, but authorizing to interpret Article XXIII of the Articles of Religion so as to recognize the governments of the country or countries.
 - e) To allow the annual conferences to adopt structures adequate to their mission while upholding mandated structures.

When adapting the investigative and trial process, each regional *Book of Discipline* shall guarantee confidentiality, protections of the accused, protection of the accusers along with the ability to adapt the process based on the legal system of each country.

6. To appoint a judicial court to determine legal questions arising from the rules, regulations, and such revised, adapted, or new sections of the regional *Discipline* enacted by the regional conference.
7. To adopt rules of procedure governing the investigation and trial of its clergy, including bishops, and lay members of the Church and to provide the necessary means and methods of implementing the said rules; provided, however, that the ordained ministers shall not be deprived of the right of trial by a clergy committee, and lay members of the Church of the right of trial by a duly constituted committee of lay members; and to make changes in the chargeable offenses and their penalties.

A regional conference or a jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, shall appoint a committee on appeals to hear and determine the appeal of a clergy or lay member of the respective conference from the decision of a committee on trial.

¶ 32. Article I.—The annual conference shall be composed of clergy and lay members. The clergy membership shall consist of deacons and elders in full connection, provisional members, associate members, and local pastors under appointment. The lay membership shall consist of professing lay members elected by each charge, the diaconal ministers, the active deaconesses, and home missionaries under episcopal appointment within the bounds of the annual conference, the conference president of United Methodist Women, the conference president of United Methodist Men, the conference lay leader, district lay leaders, the conference director of Lay Servant Ministries, conference secretary of Global Ministries (if lay), the president or equivalent officer of the conference young adult organization, the president of the conference youth organization, the chair of the annual conference college student organization, and one young person between the ages of twelve (12) and seventeen (17) and one young person between the ages of eighteen (18) and thirty (30) from each district to be selected in such a manner as may be determined by the annual conference. In the annual conferences of the regional conferences outside the USA, the four-year participation and the two-year membership requirements may be waived by the annual conference for young persons under thirty (30) years of age. Such persons must be professing members of The United Methodist Church and active participants at the time of election. Each charge served by more than one clergy shall be entitled to as many lay members as there are clergy members. The lay members shall have been for the two years next preceding their election members of The United Methodist Church and shall have been active participants in The United Methodist Church for at least four years next preceding their election.

If the lay membership should number less than the clergy members of the annual conference, the annual conference shall, by its own formula, provide for the election of additional lay members to equalize lay and clergy membership of the annual conference.

¶ 33. Article II.—The annual conference is the basic body in the Church and as such shall have reserved to it the right to vote on all constitutional amendments, on the election of clergy and lay delegates to the General Conference and their respective regional conferences, as well as jurisdictional conference if its regional conference has jurisdictions, on all matters relating to the character and conference relations of its clergy members, and on the ordination of clergy and such other rights as have not been delegated to the General Conference under the Constitution, with the exception that the lay members may not vote on matters of ordination, character, and conference relations of clergy except that the lay members of the conference board of ordained ministry and the committee on investigation may vote on matters of ordination, character, and conference relations of clergy, with the further

exception that lay members of the district committee on ordained ministry be full participating members of the district committee on ordained ministry with vote. It shall discharge such duties and exercise such powers as the General Conference under the Constitution may determine.

¶ **34. Article III.**—The annual conference shall elect clergy and lay delegates to the General Conference and to its respective regional conference as well as jurisdictional conference, if its regional conference has jurisdictions, in the manner provided in this section, Articles IV and V. Such elections shall include open nominations from the floor by the annual conference, and delegates shall be elected by a minimum of a simple majority of the ballots cast. The persons first elected up to the number determined by the ratio for representation in the General Conference shall be representatives in that body. Additional delegates shall be elected to complete the number determined by the ratio for representation in the regional conference, who, together with those first elected as above, shall be delegates in the regional conference. The additional delegates to the regional conference shall in the order of their election be the reserve delegates to the General Conference. The annual conference shall also elect reserve clergy and lay delegates to the regional conference as it may deem desirable. These reserve clergy and lay delegates to the regional conferences may act as reserve delegates to the General Conference when it is evident that not enough reserve delegates are in attendance at the General Conference.

In regional conferences with jurisdictions, all general and regional conference delegates shall be delegates to the jurisdictional conference. Whenever possible, reserve delegates to the regional conference shall also serve in order of election as delegates to the jurisdictional conference, with any reserve delegates who cannot be seated as jurisdictional delegates becoming reserve delegates to the jurisdictional conference. As needed, additional delegates shall be elected to complete the number determined by the ratio for representation in the jurisdictional conference. The annual conference may also elect additional reserve clergy and lay delegates to the jurisdictional conference as it may deem desirable.

¶ **35. Article IV.**—The clergy delegates to the General Conference and to their respective regional conference as well as jurisdictional conference, if its regional conference has jurisdictions, shall be elected from the clergy members in full connection and shall be elected by the clergy members of the annual conference or provisional annual conference who are deacons and elders in full connection, associate members, and those provisional members who have completed all of their educational requirements and local pastors who have completed course of study or an M. Div. degree or its equivalent in regional conferences outside of the USA and have served a minimum of two consecutive years under appointment immediately preceding the election.

¶ **36. Article V.**—The lay delegates to the General Conference and to their respective regional conference, as well as jurisdictional conference if its regional conference has jurisdictions, shall be elected by the lay members of the annual conference or provisional annual conference without regard to age, provided such delegates shall have been professing members of The United Methodist Church for at least two years next preceding their election, and shall have been active participants in The United Methodist Church for at least four years next preceding their election, and are members thereof within the annual conference electing them at the time of holding the General Conference and regional conferences as well as the jurisdictional conferences, if its regional conference has jurisdictions.

¶ **40. Article II.**—The number, names, and boundaries of the annual conferences and episcopal areas shall be determined by the respective regional conferences or by the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions. The authority of regional and jurisdictional conferences provided herein is not circumscribed or limited by the authority provided to the College of Bishops to arrange a plan of episcopal supervision.

¶ **46. Article II.**—The bishops shall be elected by the respective regional conferences or by the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, and consecrated in the historic manner at such time and place as may be fixed by each regional conference, provided that episcopal elections in regional conferences without jurisdictions shall be held at a regular, not an extra, session of such regional conference, except in the case where an unexpected vacancy must be filled.

¶ **48. Article IV.**—The bishops of each regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, shall constitute a College of Bishops, and such College of Bishops shall arrange the plan of episcopal supervision of the annual conferences, missionary conferences, and missions within their respective territories.

¶ **49. Article V.**—The bishops shall have residential and presidential supervision in their respective regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, in which they are elected or to which they are transferred. Bishops may be transferred from one jurisdiction to another jurisdiction for presidential and residential supervision under the following conditions: (1) The transfer of bishops may be on either of two bases: (a) a jurisdiction that receives a bishop by transfer from another jurisdiction may transfer to that jurisdiction or to a third jurisdiction one of its own bishops eligible for transfer, so that the number transferred in by each jurisdiction shall be balanced by the number transferred out; or (b) a jurisdiction may receive a bishop from another jurisdiction and not transfer out a member of its own College of Bishops. (2) No bishop shall be transferred unless that bishop shall have specifically consented. (3) No bishop shall be eligible for transfer unless the bishop shall have served one quadrennium in the jurisdiction that elected the bishop to the episcopacy. (4) All such transfers shall require the approval by a majority vote of the members present and voting of the jurisdictional committees on episcopacy of the jurisdictions that are involved. After the above procedures have been followed, the transferring bishop shall become a member of the receiving College of Bishops and shall be subject to residential assignment by that jurisdictional conference.

A bishop may be assigned by the Council of Bishops for presidential service or other temporary service in another jurisdiction than that which elected the bishop, provided that the request is made by a majority of the bishops in the jurisdiction of the proposed service.

In the case of an emergency in any regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, through the death

or disability of a bishop or other cause, the Council of Bishops may assign a bishop from another regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, to the work of the said regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, with the consent of a majority of the bishops of that regional conference or jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions.

¶ **50. Article VI.**—Bishops elected by the jurisdictions shall have life tenure. Bishops elected by a regional conference without jurisdictions shall have such tenure as the regional conference electing them shall have determined.

The regional conference or the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions, shall elect a standing committee on episcopacy to consist of one clergy and one lay delegate from each annual conference, on nomination of the annual conference delegation. The committee shall review the work of the bishops, pass on their character and official administration, and report to its respective regional conference or jurisdiction, if a region has jurisdictions, its findings for such action as the conference may deem appropriate within its constitutional warrant of power. The committee shall recommend the assignments of the bishops to their respective residences for final action by the respective regional conference or the jurisdiction, if a regional conference has jurisdictions.

These provisions shall not preclude the adoption by the General Conference of provisions for the Council of Bishops to hold its individual members accountable for their work, both as general superintendents and as presidents and residents in episcopal areas.

¶ **52. Article VIII.**—The bishops of the several regional conferences shall preside in the sessions of their respective conferences. If a regional conference has jurisdictions, the bishops shall also preside in the session of their respective jurisdictional conference.

¶ **56. Article II.**—The Judicial Council shall have authority:

1. To determine the constitutionality of any act of the General Conference upon an appeal of a majority of the Council of Bishops or one-fifth of the members of the General Conference and to determine the constitutionality of any act of a regional or jurisdictional conference upon an appeal of a majority of the bishops of that regional or jurisdictional conference or upon the appeal of one-fifth of the members of that regional or jurisdictional conference.

...

4. To hear and determine the legality of any action taken therein by any General Conference board, regional, or jurisdictional conference board or body, upon appeal by one-third of the members thereof, or upon request of the Council of Bishops or a majority of the bishops of a regional or jurisdictional conference.

...

¶ **61. Article III.**—A regional or jurisdictional conference may by a majority vote propose changes in the Constitution of the Church, and such proposed changes shall be submitted to the next General Conference. If the General Conference adopts the measure by a two-thirds vote, it shall be submitted to the annual conferences according to the provision for amendments.

The ratification process by the annual conferences for the constitutional amendments in this petition shall begin no later than 30 days after the adjournment of the postponed 2020 General Conference.

Rationale:

Worldwide regionalization creates relevance, equality, mutuality and trust across the Church without privileging one region as the center and others the peripheries. It will allow engagement in mission in our respective regional context as we proclaim the gospel to help transform the world.

These Worldwide Regionalization petitions build on the foundational work of the Christmas Covenant, a historical collaboration of grassroots and institutional efforts, with its vision of a Church that respects contextual ministry settings and celebrates the diversity of God's creation to strengthen our core mission of evangelism, discipleship, and social witness for the transformation of the world. The petitions are supported and endorsed by the Connectional Table, with its goal of creating a U.S. regional conference to provide the U.S. region parity with the central conferences and to ease the burden of U.S. legislation of the General Conference.

General Conference approved the change 586 YES, 164 NO.

Proposed Constitutional Amendment II – Inclusiveness of the Church

Amendment with changes included:

¶ **4. Article IV.**—Inclusiveness of the Church—The United Methodist Church is a part of the church universal, which is one Body in Christ. The United Methodist Church acknowledges that all persons are of sacred worth. All persons without regard to race, gender, ability, color, national origin, status,⁴ or economic condition, shall be eligible to attend its worship services, participate in its programs, receive the sacraments, upon baptism be admitted as baptized members, and upon taking vows declaring the Christian faith, become professing members in any local church in the connection.⁵ In The United Methodist Church no conference or other organizational unit of the Church shall be structured so as to exclude any member or any constituent body of the Church because of race, color, national origin, status or economic condition.⁶

4. Amended 1992.

5. Amended 2000.

6. See Judicial Council Decisions 242, 246, 340, 351, 362, 377, 398, 594, 601, and Decisions 4 and 5, Interim Judicial Council.

[If ratified, the paragraphs would read as follows:]

¶ **4. Article IV.**—Inclusiveness of the Church—The United Methodist Church is a part of the church universal, which is one Body in Christ. The United Methodist Church acknowledges that all persons are of sacred worth. All persons without regard to race, gender, ability, color, national origin, status,⁴ or economic condition, shall be eligible to attend its worship services, participate in its programs, receive the sacraments, upon baptism be admitted as baptized members, and upon taking vows declaring the Christian

faith, become professing members in any local church in the connection.⁵ In The United Methodist Church no conference or other organizational unit of the Church shall be structured so as to exclude any member or any constituent body of the Church because of race, color, national origin, status or economic condition.⁶

4. Amended 1992.

5. Amended 2000.

6. See *Judicial Council Decisions 242, 246, 340, 351, 362, 377, 398, 594, 601, and Decisions 4 and 5, Interim Judicial Council.*

Rationale:

Adding “gender” to the membership portion of the Constitution to match what is already stated in ¶ 16.1. It reinforces The UMC’s commitment to gender equity throughout our worldwide connection. It affirms that women cannot be discriminated in membership.

General Conference approved the change 607 Yes, 67 No.

Proposed Constitutional Amendment III – Racial Justice

Amendment with changes included:

¶ 5. Article V. Racial Justice—The United Methodist Church proclaims the value of each person that from God’s goodness and love, God created all persons as a God’s unique and beloved children. child of God and commits itself to the healing and wholeness of all persons. The United Methodist Church recognizes that the sin of racism has been destructive to its unity throughout its history. Racism continues to cause painful division and marginalization. The United Methodist Church shall confront and seek to eliminate racism, whether in organizations or in individuals, in every facet of its life and in society at large. The United Methodist Church shall work collaboratively with others to address concerns that threaten the cause of racial justice at all times and in all places. Racism opposes God’s law, goodness, and love and diminishes the image of God in each person. Fueled by white privilege, white supremacy, and colonialism, the sin of racism has been a destructive scourge on global society and throughout the history of The United Methodist Church. It continues to destroy our communities, harm persons, obstruct unity, and undermine God’s work in this world. Racism must be eradicated. Therefore, The United Methodist Church commits to confronting and eliminating all forms of racism, racial inequity, colonialism, white privilege, and white supremacy, in every facet of its life and in society at large.⁷

7. Amended 2000

[If ratified, the paragraphs would read as follows:]

¶ 5. Article V. Racial Justice—The United Methodist Church proclaims that from God’s goodness and love, God created all persons as God’s unique and beloved children. Racism opposes God’s law, goodness, and love and diminishes the image of God in each person. Fueled by white privilege, white supremacy, and colonialism, the sin of racism has been a destructive scourge on global society and throughout the history of The United Methodist Church. It continues to destroy our communities, harm persons, obstruct unity, and undermine God’s work in this world. Racism must be eradicated. Therefore, The United Methodist Church commits to confronting and eliminating all forms of racism, racial inequity, colonialism, white privilege, and white supremacy, in every facet of its life and in society at large.⁷

7. Amended 2000

Rationale:

The sin of racism, fueled by white privilege and colonialism, is a continual scourge on The United Methodist Church and on society, which must not be allowed to continue. The language proposed in this petition to amend the Constitution is more direct and unequivocal in both denouncing racism and declaring that The United Methodist Church must live as an actively anti-racist institution (which it currently is not). Passage of this amendment will make clear and solidify The UMC’s stand to defend against or flush out, the pathogens of resistance, fragility, inequity, discrimination, and oppression that flow through the lifeblood of this denomination.

General Conference approved the change 621 Yes, 59 No.

Proposed Constitutional Amendment IV – Clergy Delegates

Amendment with changes included:

¶ 35. Article IV.—The clergy delegates to the General Conference and to the jurisdictional or central conference shall be elected from ⁷⁴ the clergy members in full connection and shall be elected by the clergy members of the annual conference or provisional annual conference who are deacons and elders in full connection, associate members, and those provisional members who have completed all of their educational requirements and local pastors who have completed course of study or an M.Div. Master of Divinity degree from a University Senate-approved theological school or its equivalent as recognized in a central conference and have served a minimum of two consecutive years under appointment immediately preceding the election.⁷⁵

74. Amended 1996

75. See *Judicial Council Decision 1181. Amended 2008.*

[If ratified, the paragraphs would read as follows:]

¶ 35. Article IV.—The clergy delegates to the General Conference and to the jurisdictional or central conference shall be elected from ⁷⁴ the clergy members in full connection and shall be elected by the clergy members of the annual conference or provisional annual conference who are deacons and elders in full connection, associate members, and those provisional members who have completed all of their educational requirements and local pastors who have completed course of study or a Master of Divinity degree from a University Senate-approved theological school or its equivalent as recognized in a central conference and have served a minimum of two consecutive years under appointment immediately preceding the election.⁷⁵

74. Amended 1996

75. See *Judicial Council Decision 1181. Amended 2008.*

[Editorial note: The proposed change of language in this paragraph related to central conferences would be changed to reflect the necessary updates should the Proposed Constitutional Amendment related to Regionalization be ratified.]

Rationale:

Consistent with the worldwide nature of the church, the educational requirements inserted here ensure that those voting for clergy delegates have completed the denominational-standard expectations for theological education.

General Conference approved the change 547 Yes, 99 No.



CALL AND VOCATION *Cupcake Pop-in*

FRIDAY, JUNE 20 12:30–1:30 P.M.

For seminary students, Provisional Members, and RIOM mentors
Swing by for a cupcake and a quick hello!
Take a moment to recharge and connect with others in ministry.

SATURDAY, JUNE 21 12:30–1:30 P.M.

For anyone discerning a call—or walking with someone who is
Stop in to learn more about ministry pathways in the UMC.
Grab a cupcake, ask questions, and explore next steps.

The Green Call and Vocation Tent on the Lawn